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Editor-in-Chief
Journal of International Financial Markets, Institutions and Money

Dear Editor-in-Chief,

Please consider the manuscript entitled “From Apparent Edge to No-Go: A Point-in-Time, Cost-Aware Audit of Heterogeneous XAUUSD Trading Strategies” for publication as a full-length empirical research article in the *Journal of International Financial Markets, Institutions and Money*.

The manuscript addresses a central credibility problem in international-market strategy research: an apparently profitable rule is often reported without carrying the broader specification search through realistic costs, multiplicity control, temporal diagnostics, and independent-feed replication. We audit a locked universe of 39 primary XAUUSD specifications spanning 20 economic families, including price-only technical, event-response, cross-asset, long-horizon momentum, and gold-silver relative-value rules. The design preserves complete negative evidence and separates eight historically selected machine-learning combinations from primary inference.

The results are economically and methodologically informative. Positive average returns decline from 24 specifications before costs to 5 under source-native severe costs and 1 under a common fixed-stress schedule. Every specification fails at least one native acceptance gate, the smallest familywise adjusted probability is 0.446, and 7 of 20 eligible specifications fail cross-feed replication. These findings trace how apparent edges lose statistical or operational credibility within the evaluated universe, without extending the claim to universal gold-market efficiency.

The manuscript fits the journal’s coverage of international and foreign-exchange-related financial markets, information and speculation, and empirical market behavior. It also speaks directly to prior articles in the journal on intraday technical trading in precious metals and false-discovery-controlled technical-analysis profitability, while engaging recent evidence on large technical-rule universes, gold-price prediction, volatility forecasting, and the state-dependent investment role of gold.

The submission includes the full and anonymized CAS-format manuscripts, title page, highlights, supplementary material, declarations, figure sources, machine-readable result tables, and an independently audited replication package. The consolidated computation uses reference samples ending in 2024 and excludes historical result files from runner inputs. All figures are reproducible data visualizations derived from the frozen result tables.

This is a single-author manuscript. The research received no specific grant from any funding agency in the public, commercial, or not-for-profit sectors, and the author declares no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have influenced the work. The project repository is identified in the data-and-code-availability statement, while versioned records remain in the replication metadata.

Thank you for considering this work.

Sincerely,

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